

The Examination of Pressure Politics in Mormon, Amish, and Korean Cultures

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Introduction: Politics as a Cultural Universal



Mormons: Institutional Power & Cultural Solidarity



~72% of Utah identifies as LDS → church culture defines political boundaries



Church organized down to the neighborhood (ward) level



Example: A bishop mobilized 100+ parishioners to the state capitol in **2 hours**

Mormons: The Church- State Tension

LDS Doctrine & Covenants (1835)
counsels separation of religion and
civil authority

Members face real dilemmas: loyalty
to church leaders vs. individual
conscience

Political influence operates through
internalized norms, not coercion

Mormons: Policy Consequences



Conservative LDS cultural values delayed progressive legislation for decades



Public housing programs (passed federally in 1930s, delayed in Utah)



Land use planning: defeated in state referendum, costly consequences



Cultural pressure politics shapes policy even *without* formal institutional action

Amish: The Political Paradox

Core belief:
separation from the
"world" — politics is
spiritually dangerous

Yet the Amish have
repeatedly and
successfully engaged
the state

Key principle: lesser
values (avoid politics)
yield to higher ones
(preserve
independence)

Amish: The Social Security Battle

- Theological objection: insurance implies a lack of faith in God & community mutual aid
- 1954: Amish bishops petitioned Congress directly; whole church districts signed petitions
- **1965**: Amish representatives testify before the U.S. Senate → Social Security Bill H.R. 6675 grants exemption
- Lesson: Clarity of message matters more than organizational resources

Amish: The Education Fight

Resisted mandatory secondary education as a threat to religious formation

1937: Pamphlet to Pennsylvania officials with implicit threat to withdraw from public schools

1971 Iowa case: Invited Governor Ray to a one-room schoolhouse:

The Sunday service as a political forum: religious cohesion = political cohesion

- children performed songs, governor was moved → exemptions granted

Korean Communities: Informal Resistance to Authority



Traditional Korea: no formal political rights for ordinary people



Offices were *bought and sold* — officials pressured to extract wealth quickly



The central government's unofficial rule: if the prefect pushes the people too far and they revolt, the government will not intervene

Korean Communities: Collective Action as a Check on Power

- Communities could *seize a corrupt official* to signal limits had been reached
- Communities could also *seize a fair official* and demand his reappointment
- As local accountability declined in the 19th century, informal mechanisms became less effective

Korean Communities: From Tradition to Democracy



- Democratic transition of 1987 opened formal channels for popular pressure
- Intense public demand → rapid expansion of university enrollment (Isozaki 2019)
- Same underlying logic: collective purpose shapes political outcomes regardless of formal structures

Comparative Analysis

	Mormon	Amish	Korean
Mechanism	Church infrastructure	Petitions & personal visits	Collective resistance & threat
Driver	Religious solidarity	Theological values	Community survival
Relationship to politics	Engaged but ambivalent	Avoidant but pragmatic	Informal, outside formal channels
Key example	2-hour capitol mobilization	Senate testimony (1965)	Seizing the prefect

Conclusion

Political power is **not** confined to formal institutions or elections

Organized communities can shape outcomes through collective purpose and moral clarity

All three cases confirm: political authority ultimately depends on community consent

Pressure politics, across all cultures, is how communities assert that truth

Discussion / Q&A

What form of pressure politics do you find most effective, and why?

What form of pressure politics exists in your culture(s)?